

4. Physical Evidence

4.1. Description of the site.

This description is from the 2005 CMP. References to figures have been brought up to date.

The War Memorial Hospital is situated on a ridge of the highest point in the eastern suburbs. The site is bounded by Birrell Street, Carrington Road, Church Street and Bronte Road. Portions of this block, including a strip along Birrell Street and the corner site on Bronte Road and Church Street are privately owned. A number of the semi-detached houses along Birrell Street have been purchased by the hospital over the years.

The site contains a very fine group of high Victorian buildings, of which the most elaborate house in the area is Edina (Vickery Building), a large two storey Victorian house with a tower. The house has an extant stable block to the south west corner of the site that has now been converted to workshops. The site contains extensive remains of the former Victorian garden and trees, particularly in the terraced lawns near Edina. It also retains pathways, steps and drives from that time.

There is also a group of three, two storey, boom period, Italianate/Gothic houses towards Birrell Street that flank an entry drive, Edina Avenue, leading from the street to the main house.

There are two smaller houses in the Federation/Inter war style along Edina Drive that have been converted for hospital use.

The grounds have been developed for hospital use, and latterly aged care and rehabilitation services and contain a large number of buildings built for these services. Most prominent is the Morgan Wing, a long, three storey Mediterranean style building to the east of Edina with a four storey tower flanked by a decorative terracotta tile roof.

The site slopes east to west. The lower portion of the site has been heavily redeveloped for aged care accommodation. There are a number of temporary modern sheds and portacabins around the site and a network of drive and parking areas.

Two sections of ornate, original gates and fence sections survive on Carrington Road behind the Vickery Building and on the corner of Birrell Street and Bronte Road. There is a small section of low sandstone fence to Bronte Road and a higher section along church road that is in part a retaining wall and is incorporated into some of the buildings along this boundary. The site contains extensive landscaping and planting. This has been identified in Figure 9 below.

The site has much of its earlier Victoria garden layout and plantings, though this has been overlaid with plantings from each era of development. The upper portion of the site at Edina is laid out with terraced lawns to the front of the house with a turning circle and paths on the central axis of the house. The lawns are planted with mature Figs, two very tall Norfolk Island Pines and later Phoenix Palms. The Norfolk Island Pines are visible from many aspects around the site and beyond.

There are some interesting specimen trees indigenous to Queensland that may have been selected plantings in the lower garden (Queensland Firewheel tree, *Podocarpus* sp.)(no.14 in figure 9).

To the north is a drive and pathway that form the main entrance from Birrell Street that are lined with Phoenix palms and later, low planting.